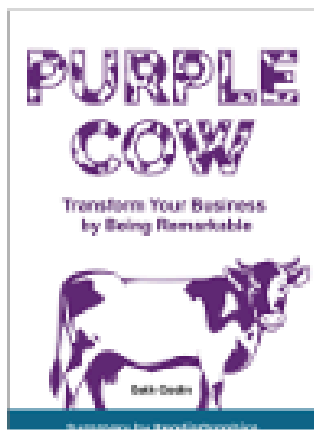




PURPLE COW

Transform Your Business by Being Remarkable

SETH GODIN



The Big “So What”

The world of marketing has changed forever, and traditional forms of marketing no longer work. The best way to launch a new product/service or build a brand successfully is to be remarkable. This book explains why and how to build Purple Cows that people will notice and talk about.



Introduction



In the past, businesses typically used the 5Ps of marketing to guide their marketing strategy and tactics. Depending on the company or individual, the 5Ps could include: product, pricing, promotion, positioning, publicity, packaging, pass-along, and permission.



Today's marketing climate calls for a new P—the “Purple Cow”.

- The Purple Cow refers to something remarkable, i.e. something worth noticing and talking about. Imagine you're a city-dweller driving through the countryside. Initially, you may feel excited to see brown cows grazing in the fields, but you'll quickly lose interest after a few hours of the same scenery. Then, you notice a purple cow in the field. Suddenly, you're sitting up, snapping photos and sharing it with everyone—because it's unique and remarkable.
- This book is written in many short, bite-sized chapters, each discussing a concept or insight about marketing. In this summary, we've consolidated the ideas into 2 main sections:
 - (i) The New World of Marketing; and
 - (ii) Creating your Purple Cows.

KEY QUOTES

“This book is about the why, the what, and the how of remarkable.”

“Marketers for years have talked about the five Ps of marketing...This is a book about a new P, a P that is suddenly exceptionally important.”

“Remarkable marketing is the art of building things worth noticing right into your product or service.”



The New World of Marketing



Marketing has changed dramatically in the past decades:

- Before the age of TV and advertising, people relied primarily on word of mouth to discover great products/services, such as the market stalls with the freshest produce.
- During the advertising era, companies with big budgets could spend money on mass media ads (e.g. TV, newspapers, magazine) to reach masses of people, sell more products, then invest the profits in more advertising to grow their market share. Mass-market ads were effective since there were relatively fewer advertisers and choices for consumers.
- We're now in the post-advertising era, where the market is so saturated with ads that consumers have become indifferent to them. Successful marketing now hinges on the ability to solve consumers' problems and get word-of-mouth referrals. To do so, marketers must first grab consumers' attention and have a solution that works.



Today's consumers are still looking for great solutions to their problems. The key marketing challenge is this: there are now more and more choices, and people have less and less time. So, they simply ignore the unwanted messages. Even satisfied customers are less likely to share about a product unless it's truly exceptional.

- You can only sell a product/service to someone who has the money, time, or desire to buy it. The person must:
 - (i) Be able to afford your product;
 - (ii) Have the time to listen to your pitch/message; and
 - (iii) Want the product after hearing the pitch.
- For example, if you were the first to invent aspirin, it would've been much easier to get people's attention. Today, to sell a new brand of aspirin, you must:

KEY QUOTES

"The world has changed. There are far more choices, but there is less and less time to sort them out."

"As consumers, we're too busy to pay attention to advertising, but we're desperate to find good stuff that solves our problems."

KEY QUOTES

- (i) Find a way to reach the people who need pain relief;
 - (ii) Find those who're willing to consider a new brand; and
 - (iii) Convince them to choose your brand over your competitors (including established brands that've had years to hone their products and ads).
- Today, results from mass-media advertising are dismal despite the high costs. If you reach 1 mil people but only 0.001% make a purchase, that translates to just 10 customers.
- (i) Godin did an experiment with people reading the Wall Street Journal at a hotel lobby. He asked if they could name 2 companies that had run a full-page ad, if they could recognize the company (after he hid the logo on the ad), or if they had ever enquired about a product/service after seeing the ads. The answer was "no" to all 3 questions.
 - (ii) Famous marketer Sergio Zyman admitted that 2 of Coke's most famous commercials—"I'd like to teach the world to sing" and "Mean Joe Greene"—didn't generate any additional revenue.

"Stop advertising and start innovating."



Why You Need Purple Cows



- According to Godin, 80% of the new entrants to Interbrand's top 100 brand list succeeded due to word of mouth, not extensive advertising. The most wildly-successful solutions tend to be outliers, i.e. they're unusually fast or slow, big or small, luxurious or affordable.
- Each of these companies stood out because they didn't play by the rules—and neither should you:
- (i) JetBlue Airways went with a low-cost structure, underused airports, and non-union staff, at a time when air travel was dominated by full-service airlines with unionized staff.
 - (ii) Starbucks invented the coffee bar concept, at a time when canned supermarket coffee was the norm.
 - (iii) Vanguard created low-cost index funds that full-service brokers simply couldn't compete with.

"Services that are worth talking about get talked about."

- If you try to copy the market leader, you'll always lag behind. More importantly, you'll never be remarkable since your idea/approach won't be unique.
- Offering the lowest price is also not a good strategy since your rivals can always undercut you. Being a Purple Cow means offering drastically lower prices *and* higher value by fundamentally changing how a product is designed, produced or delivered—like what IKEA did with home furnishing.



In “*Crossing the Chasm*”, Geoff Moore presents the adoption curve which explains how new technology moves through the market. Although the book was written for high-tech solutions, the insights apply to virtually *any* product/service in any market.

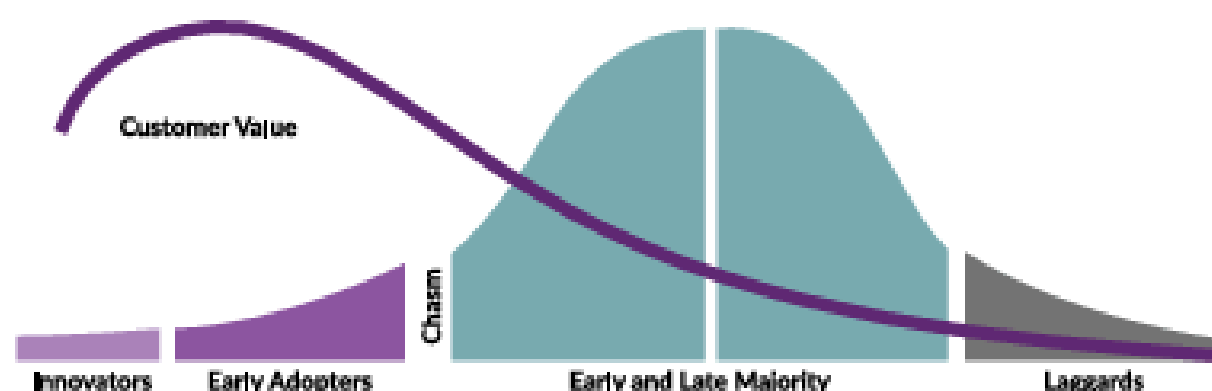


Diagram adapted from *Crossing the Chasm* (by Geoff Moore) and *Purple Cow* (by Seth Godin)

- Innovators are the first to try new products, not because they need the products but because they simply love new solutions.
- After them comes the early adopters who actually benefit from the products. They're actively looking for good solutions to their problems, and will pay for such products or services.
- The early and late majority represent the bulk of the market. However, they're happy with existing solutions and will ignore your marketing messages. The only way to get their attention is by getting the early adopters to embrace your solution and spread the word.
- The laggards start using the products when people are already moving on to newer solutions, e.g. they start using CDs when people are ready to move on to mp3s.



In short, a new product/service cannot reach the mass market without first going through the innovators and early adopters. If you target the mass market directly, you'll fail because:

KEY QUOTES

"The leader is the leader because he did something remarkable. And that remarkable thing is now taken—it's no longer remarkable when you do it."

KEY QUOTES

- Products that seem safe enough for the masses will be too boring for innovators and early adopters.
- You'll also need to spend millions (or even billions) to advertise directly to the masses. Yet, the early/late majority will ignore your marketing messages by default. If you fail to grab their attention, you won't have enough resources to try again.



Instead, aim to win over the "sneezers" among the early adopters. These are people who can spread contagious ideas (which Godin calls "ideaviruses") to heavily influence the rest of the curve.

- Don't try to target everyone. Instead, focus on a specific niche to increase the chances that you can design an irresistible solution and reach a critical mass of people through a few sneezers.
- Use targeted marketing with the goal of getting the sneezers (early adopters with influence) to try your solution and recommend it to others. For example, when Zespri launched their new kiwi fruit with golden flesh and an edible peel, they used in-store tasting in upscale Latino groceries to reach the right people.
- Most importantly, design a virus-worthy product that can attract the early adopters *and* help them to promote it to others easily. To evaluate a product/idea's potential as an ideavirus, consider:
 - (i) Is it easy to spread your idea?
 - (ii) How often will people share the idea?
 - (iii) How closely-knit are the communities? How far do they trust one another?
 - (iv) How influential are the potential sneezers?
 - (v) Will the idea persist over time or fade quickly?
- Once you've dominated the niche and have sneezers spreading the ideavirus for you, it's much easier to reach the masses without spending millions on advertising.

"Don't try to make a product for everybody, because that is a product for nobody."

"A brand (or a new product offering) is nothing more than an idea. Ideas that spread are more likely to succeed than those that don't."



In short, the rule of marketing has fundamentally changed.

KEY QUOTES

"The old rules don't work so well any more. Marketing is dead."

"What's missing isn't the ideas. It's the will to execute them."

"The best the timid can hope for is to be unnoticed. Criticism comes to those who stand out."

"Being safe is risky."

- In the past, the rule was to create safe products that can be marketed to the masses. Now, the new rule is to create remarkable products that will attract the right people.
- Since every Cow is unique, there's no fool-proof formula for creating a Purple Cow. However, you can use the principles, ideas and concepts below to increase your chances of success.



Creating Your Purple Cow



Dare to Stick Out and Be Remarkable

 To build a Purple Cow, you need the courage to take risks. Purple Cows are so rare because most people are afraid to stick out.

- All great artists, authors, chefs, and businesses have their share of failures and criticisms. If you're remarkable, you will get both attention and criticisms. Moreover, you can't predict which ideas will succeed, so you'll definitely experience failures. Ultimately, you can either be safe and boring, or unique and virus-worthy. You can't be both.
- Being safe is riskier than being different. A safe, boring idea makes you invisible in a crowded marketplace so you'll certainly fail. A bold idea at least gives you a shot at greatness. Moreover, the more others avoid risks/criticisms, the greater your opportunity to stand out as a Purple Cow. For example:
 - (i) In the past, chairs were treated as boring complements to desks. Then in 1994, *Herman Miller* introduced the Aeron chair which looked and worked differently, and cost much more at \$750 each. The idea was risky, but it paid off.
 - (ii) When *Lionel Poilane* inherited his dad's French bakery, he didn't just continue to do the same thing. His bakery was the first in France to introduce organic flour, and to create wood-fired oven-baked sourdough bread using just flour, water, sea-salt and starter. His innovation paid

off, and the Poilane bread can now be found across the globe.

- Purple Cows are not meant to appeal to everyone. If you have creative people working on your Purple Cows, give them the space to develop exceptional ideas for a niche market. Don't insist on using focus groups or user tests to prove the concept with mainstream customers.



It's not enough to create something that's "very good". The more noisy, crowded or rigid a market is, the more you need a truly remarkable Purple Cow to cut through the clutter.

- It's better to go for a few dramatic improvements that the right customers will care about, than to keep churning out meaningless marketing campaigns. Take 1-2 seasons off to develop promotions or activities that are worth noticing. For years, Ben & Jerry's didn't run any short-term promotions. Instead, they generated massive buzz and publicity just by giving out free ice-cream once a year.



Go for Targeted Marketing, not Mass Advertisements



Not all customers are equally profitable. Differentiate your customers with the goal of finding the group that's (i) the most profitable or (ii) the most likely to sneeze. Then, focus on reaching, cultivating, and rewarding this group. Ignore all others.

- Go for the smallest market niche you can serve remarkably:
 - (i) Which is 1 underserved market niche that you can dominate?
 - (ii) What product could be irresistible to this market?
- Match your product to the market niche. For example, if you're selling frozen comfort-food, it makes more sense to target overworked house-husbands than people watching a gourmet cooking show. You can:
 - (i) Figure out your audience, then solve their problem; or
 - (ii) Start with a problem you can solve, then figure out the people who'd love your solution.

KEY QUOTES

"Very good is an everyday occurrence and hardly worth mentioning."

"Irresistible (for the right niche) is just remarkable."



Develop a slogan or positioning statement that captures what's remarkable and true about you.

- Slogans are so powerful because they can convey a message in seconds. They don't even have to involve words. For example, Tiffany's blue box conveys elegance and quality, while the name "The Leaning Tower of Pisa" speaks for itself.
- If you're in an intangible business, consider what's remarkable about your solution and your people (i.e. you or your team).
- Back these up with real-life stories that sneezers can spread.



Keep Exploring the Edges



The best way to create Purple Cows is to constantly explore the fringes and find/test ways to make your products remarkable:

- Go through the list of marketing Ps: Product, Pricing, Promotion, Positioning, Publicity, Packaging, Pass-along, and Permission.
- For each area, identify the edges that you can explore. List down valuable attributes and consider if/how you can be the "mostest" in each area. For example, can you be the most durable, simple, complex, caring, cool, fun, exclusive, personalized, or value-for-money?
- Test which one(s) will most likely deliver the desired results.



Use the ideas and examples below to stimulate your imagination:

- What ideas can you gain from other industries? How do their most remarkable solutions stand out from the rest?
- Challenge the things that are "just not done" in your industry. Or, study a competitor with a Purple Cow—can you outdo them by going in the opposite direction?
- How can you combine different ideas to come up with a remarkable one?

KEY QUOTES

"Explore the limits. What if you're the cheapest, the fastest, the slowest, the hottest, the coldest, the easiest, the most efficient, the loudest, the most hated, the copycat, the outsider, the hardest, the oldest, the newest, the . . . most!"

"You have to go where the competition is not. The farther the better."

KEY QUOTES

"Instead of selling what we wanted to sell, we sold what people wanted us to sell, and then figured out how to make money doing it."
—Brad Anderson, former CEO of Best Buy

- Can you redefine what you're selling? Most paint companies assume that they're selling paint. Dutch Boy realized that customers are actually buying painted walls, so they redesigned their paint cans to be easier to carry, pour from, and close—a simple change that delivered a huge increase in sales.
- Can you get users to change their behavior to optimize your product's performance? For example, elevators are expensive and take up valuable space for lift lobbies. If each elevator stops at every floor, you'll need many elevators in a tall building. Otis came up with a solution to this problem—they created a central control pad for passengers to enter the floor they're going to. By the time they reach the lift lobby, an elevator is already assigned to bring them directly to the desired floor. This allows fewer lifts to serve more passengers more quickly.
- What will it take for your product/service to be so unusual that people start to spread spoofs or parodies of it? However, being remarkable doesn't mean being ridiculous or outrageous just for the sake of being so. Focus on the purpose behind your outrageousness, and build it into the product itself.
- Can you create a collectible version of your product? For example, Curad successfully challenged established leader Band-Aid by introducing colorful bandages with cool characters. This soon became a favorite with kids.
- Can you stand out by being honest? In France, McDonald's subsidized a report that recommended fast-food consumption at most once a week. This honest message reached more people than advertisements asking people to consume more.



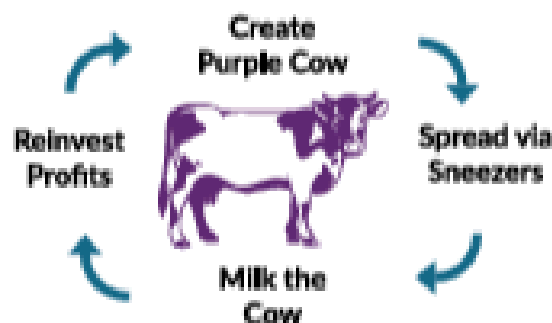
Go for Short, Repeated Development Cycles



The Purple Cow is just a part of the product life cycle, most suited for growth or starting something new. However, any idea—no matter how fresh or remarkable—will eventually lose its novelty. Once a market leader's product becomes common and boring, it can be disrupted by new Purple Cows.

So, it isn't enough to create 1 Purple Cow. You must continually reinvest the money to develop new Cows.

- Once you've crossed the chasm to capture the early/late majority market, hand the product to another team to milk the Cow. Aim to extend the Cow and profit from it as long as possible by improving and refreshing the product.
- Concurrently invent a new Purple Cow before the original one becomes boring and mainstream.
 - (i) Ideally, target the same audience. Gather the contacts of the top 20% of customers who love what you do, and get their permission to reach out when you launch your next Purple Cow. Do not spam them with marketing messages in the meantime.
 - (ii) Be prepared to keep failing, and to repeat the cycle over and over again.



You can't fix something without knowing what's broken. Look for the fastest and most cost-effective ways to measure meaningful outcomes so you can keep improving and refining your approach. For example, Zara changes its clothing line every 3-4 weeks, monitors what works and doesn't, then adjusts its lineup.



Find People with "Otaku"



Godin describes the Japanese word "otaku" as something between a hobby and an obsession. For example, only people who're truly passionate about science fiction will attend a science fiction convention. Engage early adopters with otaku, i.e. people who care enough to learn about your product and tell others about it. Get their help to refine and launch your Purple Cows.



Often, the creators of Purple Cows are also passionate about their products, e.g. Starbuck's Howard Schultz is a coffee lover himself.

KEY QUOTES

"The Purple Cow is not a cheap shortcut. It is, however, your best (perhaps only) strategy for growth."

"It's about being irresistible to a tiny group of easily reached sneezers with otaku."

- Even if you're not personally passionate about your products, you can get to know your target audience intimately in 2 ways:
 - (i) Look for people/agencies in your industry with a track record of launching remarkable products, and hire or learn from them. Immerse yourself in fan magazines, conferences and design reviews to get in the heads of people who care deeply about the product, so you can make something they'll love and share.
 - (ii) Build processes and a culture where people systematically and repeatedly test new prototypes and explore new ideas.
- Equip your people with the innovation, design and influence skills they'll need to launch amazing solutions.
 - (i) Send your designers for marketing courses and send your marketers for design courses etc.
 - (ii) Involve your marketers in the product conceptualization and development, so you can design the product's marketing into the product itself.



You can also be a Purple Cow in your career. People who're truly remarkable don't have to worry about their job-search techniques. They get recommended by others or sought out by companies.

- Position yourself as the go-to-person for a narrow niche, e.g. as a publicist for plastic surgeons; and/or
- Build up a remarkable resume over time. Don't try to be a Purple Cow only when you're looking for a job. Regularly take on high-profile projects, and allow yourself to take risks (and fail). These will naturally make your resume stand out.

KEY QUOTES

"If you are a marketer who doesn't know how to invent, design, influence, adapt, and ultimately discard products, then you're no longer a marketer. You're deadwood."

"Remarkable people with remarkable careers seem to switch jobs with far less effort."

"The path to lifetime job security is to be remarkable."



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

This book is written in short, easy-to-read chapters, with numerous examples to illustrate how Purple Cows can be created in any area—from hotels to cars, supermarkets, or even salt. Although the book was first published in 2002, many of the key ideas are still

applicable today. For more ideas and resources, do visit Godin's website (www.sethgodin.com) or his blog (<https://seths.blog>).

About the Author



Seth W. Godin (born 1960) is an American author and entrepreneur. Godin previously founded and sold a book packaging business. He then launched Yoyodyne to promote permission marketing. In 1998, Yoyodyne was sold to Yahoo! for about \$30 million and became Godin Yahoo's vice president of direct marketing. In March 2006, Godin launched Squidoo which was sold to HubPages in 2014. Godin has authored 20 books.

KEY QUOTES